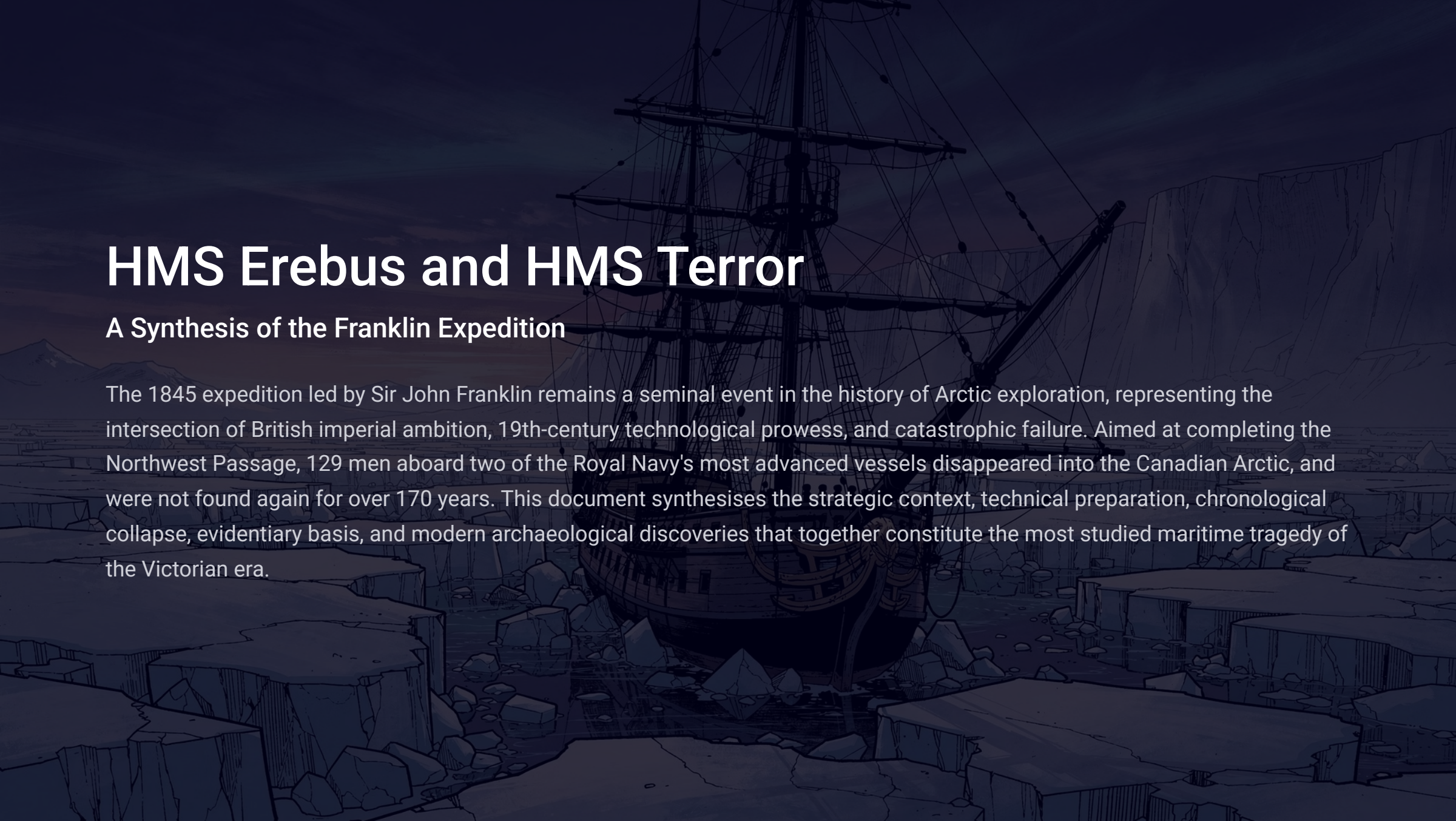


Into the Ice: The Franklin Expedition of 1845

The Disappearance of Sir John Franklin and the Fate of the Royal Navy's Finest

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HMS Erebus and HMS Terror

A Synthesis of the Franklin Expedition

The 1845 expedition led by Sir John Franklin remains a seminal event in the history of Arctic exploration, representing the intersection of British imperial ambition, 19th-century technological prowess, and catastrophic failure. Aimed at completing the Northwest Passage, 129 men aboard two of the Royal Navy's most advanced vessels disappeared into the Canadian Arctic, and were not found again for over 170 years. This document synthesises the strategic context, technical preparation, chronological collapse, evidentiary basis, and modern archaeological discoveries that together constitute the most studied maritime tragedy of the Victorian era.



I. Strategic Context and Objectives

The Franklin expedition was a high-stakes endeavour driven by the British Admiralty's post-Napoleonic focus on geographic prizes and naval science. With the Napoleonic Wars concluded, the Royal Navy found itself with both surplus officers and a renewed appetite for exploration as a form of productive imperial ambition. The Northwest Passage long imagined as a maritime link through the Canadian Arctic between the Atlantic and Pacific was valued as a potential shortcut for trade with Asia, sparing commercial vessels the arduous routes around the Cape of Good Hope or Cape Horn.

The Northwest Passage

A maritime link through the Canadian Arctic archipelago connecting Atlantic and Pacific waters. Long sought as a commercial shortcut to Asia, it represented the foremost remaining geographic prize of the age.

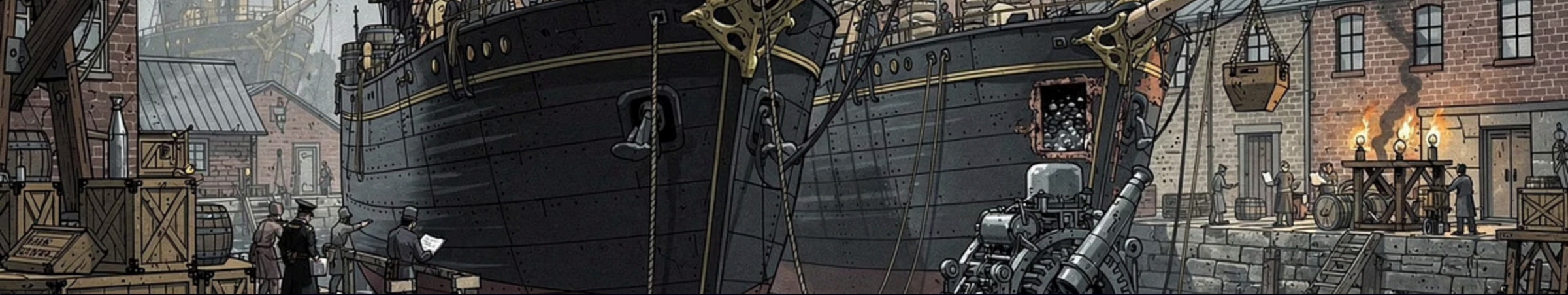
Imperial Prestige

The British government offered a £20,000 reward for the passage's discovery. Beyond financial gain, success was a matter of national prestige and the definitive resolution of a long-standing scientific and cartographic problem.

The Mission Objective

Sailing in May 1845, the expedition intended to connect known eastern Arctic waterways with charted western waters, effectively completing the map of the Northwest Passage and cementing British dominance in polar exploration.

The selection of Sir John Franklin to command the expedition reflected both his prior polar experience and his standing within the naval establishment. Franklin had previously led overland Arctic expeditions in 1819 and 1825, though those journeys had been marked by severe hardship. The confidence with which the Admiralty despatched the 1845 mission with 129 men and three years of provisions speaks to an institutional conviction that technological advancement had fundamentally altered the calculus of polar risk. That confidence would prove tragically misplaced.



II. Vessels and Technical Preparation

The Admiralty's selection of "bomb vessels" for the mission was a deliberate and informed choice, shaped by practical experience rather than optimism alone. Originally designed to withstand the violent recoil of heavy mortars, these ships possessed exceptionally robust hulls and unusually strong framing, a structural quality that translated directly into resilience against the crushing pressures of Arctic pack ice. In an era before specialized icebreakers, this made them among the best available candidates for a voyage that might require repeated contact with frozen seas, ice ridges, and prolonged overwintering. Both HMS Erebus and HMS Terror had prior polar service records, having participated in James Clark Ross's Antarctic expedition of 1839–1843, which gave them not only proven seaworthiness in extreme conditions but also a reputation as vessels already tested at the edges of known navigation.

Feature	HMS Erebus	HMS Terror
Previous Service	Ross's Antarctic expedition; proven polar vessel with hard-won experience in cold-weather operations	Prior Arctic and Antarctic service record, giving it exceptional credibility for a northern campaign
Hull Technology	Reinforced hull; auxiliary steam engine; internal heating to improve endurance and crew survival	Reinforced hull; auxiliary steam engine; internal heating to support prolonged operations in sealed ice
Wreck Discovered	2014, 80 km south of King William Island	2016, Terror Bay; remarkably intact condition

Crew and Provisions

With 129 officers and men embarked, the expedition was assembled on a scale that reflected high institutional confidence and a willingness to sustain a large, disciplined crew in isolation. Three years of provisions were loaded aboard, signaling that the Admiralty expected not a quick dash through open water but a long campaign in which the ships might be trapped, delayed, or forced to winter in ice far from any support.

Engineering Achievement

The combination of strengthened hulls, locomotive-derived steam engines for auxiliary propulsion, and coal-fired internal heating systems represented the peak of mid-19th-century British naval engineering. These innovations were intended to reduce reliance on wind, improve maneuverability in narrow leads, and keep the vessels habitable through the Arctic winter. Taken together, the equipment embodied the era's faith that mechanical power and disciplined planning could overcome environmental extremes that had defeated earlier expeditions.



III. The Chronology of Collapse

The expedition's failure unfolded not as a single catastrophic event but as a sequence of five distinct phases, each one narrowing the crews' options and weakening the institutional discipline that had initially sustained them. In its first stage, the voyage still looked like a managed Royal Navy enterprise: the ships were wintered, routines were maintained, and the officers could plausibly imagine that patience and preparation would carry the expedition through another season. But the apparent order concealed a deeper fragility. As the ice failed to release the ships, survival began to depend less on procedure than on adaptation, improvisation, and the ability to absorb repeated shocks. The expedition's tragedy lies precisely in that transition, from a planned imperial mission to a prolonged crisis in which every decision had to be made under worsening physical and psychological pressure. Reconstructing that progression requires combining the Victory Point note, Inuit oral testimony, and forensic archaeological evidence gathered over more than a century of investigation.

Five phases of decline

These five phases did not simply follow one another in a neat sequence. They compounded. Each stage reduced food security, morale, mobility, and command cohesion, so that the next crisis arrived at a weaker threshold than the last. Ice entrapment turned into prolonged immobility; immobility into dependence on dwindling stores; dependence into administrative breakdown; breakdown into desertion of the ships; and abandonment into an exposed overland retreat across an unforgiving landscape. What began as an expedition with the full backing of imperial logistics ended in a struggle where even small failures, fatigue, illness, frost, hunger, and confusion became mutually reinforcing forces.

- 1. Orderly wintering**
The first phase preserved the outward structure of naval life. Officers enforced routine, the vessels remained habitable, and the crew still had the confidence that comes from operating within familiar procedures.
- 2. Entrapment**
When the ships became locked in ice in September 1846, movement and resupply were suspended. The expedition was no longer sailing through danger, but waiting inside it.
- 3. Leadership transition**
By June 1847, command changes signaled that the crisis had become irreversible. Leadership could no longer restore momentum, only manage deterioration and uncertainty.
- 4. Abandonment**
In April 1848, the crews left the ships, a decision that marked the collapse of maritime order and the loss of the vessels as functioning centers of survival.
- 5. Final march**
The last phase was a desperate overland attempt to escape the Arctic, a march defined by exhaustion, isolation, and the progressive failure of every remaining support system.



Phase 1: Orderly Wintering (1845–1846)

After entering Lancaster Sound in the summer of 1845, the expedition spent its first winter at Beechey Island, a desolate outpost in the Nunavut territory of Canada. In Royal Navy practice, an "orderly wintering" meant preserving the routines, discipline, and administrative habits of a ship at sea even while the vessel was immobilized by ice. The ships were secured, watches were maintained, scientific observations were presumably recorded, and officers continued to enforce hierarchy, hygiene, and labor discipline. From the outside, the expedition would have appeared to be a model of controlled overwintering rather than a force in crisis.

Nevertheless, the shadow of mortality appeared early. Three crew members died during this first winter and were buried at Beechey Island: John Torrington (stoker, HMS Terror), John Hartnell (able seaman, HMS Erebus), and William Braine (Royal Marine, HMS Erebus). Their graves, rediscovered in the 20th century, became some of the most important physical witnesses to the expedition's hidden fragility. The fact that the first winter produced multiple deaths suggests that the crew was already facing stresses beyond normal hardship, including poor nutrition, cold exposure, and the accumulated strain of confinement. Rather than being a stable foundation for the voyage, this first winter exposed how vulnerable the expedition was even before the decisive failures of the later years.

Forensic analysis of the remarkably preserved remains, made possible by permafrost conditions, was carried out in detail during Owen Beattie's 1984 investigations. Beattie and his team exhumed the Beechey Island graves and subjected the bodies to modern forensic examination, including pathology, toxicology, and environmental analysis. Their work transformed the graves from memorial sites into crucial scientific evidence, allowing researchers to reconstruct aspects of diet, health, and mortality that had long remained speculative. The examinations suggested that the men died with signs of physical decline that may have reflected the expedition's broader medical vulnerability at an early stage.

Lead levels detected in all three men were notably elevated, reinforcing the hypothesis that lead poisoning may have been one factor in the expedition's deterioration. One proposed source was the solder used to seal the expedition's tinned provisions, which may have allowed lead contamination into the food supply. Scholars have debated how directly this exposure could have affected cognition, judgment, and physical resilience. Some argue that chronic lead ingestion may have compounded fatigue, gastrointestinal illness, and mental confusion, making an already dangerous situation worse. Others caution that the evidence is not strong enough to make lead the primary explanation for the expedition's collapse, pointing instead to scurvy, starvation, cold stress, infection, and the cumulative burden of Arctic survival. The result is a broader scholarly consensus that lead was likely one contributory stressor, but not a single defining cause of failure.



Phase 2: Entrapment (September 1846 – April 1848)

Following the successful first winter at Beechey Island, the expedition pressed southward through Peel Sound in the summer of 1846, navigating toward Victoria Strait. This southerly movement represented progress toward the expedition's objective and must have generated optimism aboard both vessels. That optimism was extinguished on 12 September 1846, when the ships became "beset", the technical naval term for a vessel rendered immobile by surrounding pack ice, in the waters north of King William Island.

The ships remained trapped in the ice for 19 months, an unbroken period of immobilisation during which supplies diminished, crew health deteriorated, and the prospect of a voluntary escape grew increasingly remote.

The entrapment in Victoria Strait was catastrophic in its duration. Unlike a brief beset from which a vessel might be freed by shifting ice or changing winds, the Erebus and Terror remained locked in position through two full polar winters. Victoria Strait was especially hazardous because it functioned as a narrow corridor between landmasses where currents, tidal forces, and the repeated compression of sea ice could rapidly create dense pressure ridges and stubborn multiyear floes. Once the ships were caught there, the surrounding ice was less likely to break up quickly than in more open waters, making escape dependent on conditions that rarely aligned in the expedition's favor.

The physical and psychological toll of this prolonged immobilisation upon the crew cannot be overstated. Men who had departed England with a three-year supply of provisions now found those provisions being consumed without any corresponding progress toward the expedition's goal or toward home. The monotony of the icebound months likely sharpened anxiety, fostered uncertainty about rescue, and made every change in weather feel like a possible turning point that never quite arrived.

Location of Entrapment

Victoria Strait, north-northwest of King William Island, a narrow and exposed passage where tidal flow, coastal geography, and compressed pack ice combined to encourage severe multi-year ice accumulation.

Duration of Immobilisation

19 months, spanning from September 1846 to the abandonment of the ships in April 1848. This extended entrapment steadily consumed the expedition's remaining provisions, fuel, and physical reserves while offering little hope of release.

Cumulative Deterioration

Declining rations, potential lead toxicity, scurvy, and prolonged confinement in extreme cold created conditions of progressive physical and cognitive decline across the entire complement of officers and men. Isolation, routine disruption, and mounting uncertainty likely intensified the strain.



Phase 3: Leadership Transition and Mortality (June 1847)

The Victory Point note, the sole surviving written record from the expedition, confirms that Sir John Franklin died on 11 June 1847, having been trapped in the ice for nine months. As a historical document, it is indispensable because it provides the last firm, dated evidence of the expedition's fate before the final breakdown of orderly record keeping. The precise cause of his death is unrecorded. He was 61 years of age at the time of his death, and the physical demands of prolonged Arctic entrapment on a man of his age and constitution would have been considerable. Command of the expedition passed to Captain Francis Rawdon Moira Crozier, commander of HMS Terror, an experienced and able officer who had served with Ross on the Antarctic expedition.

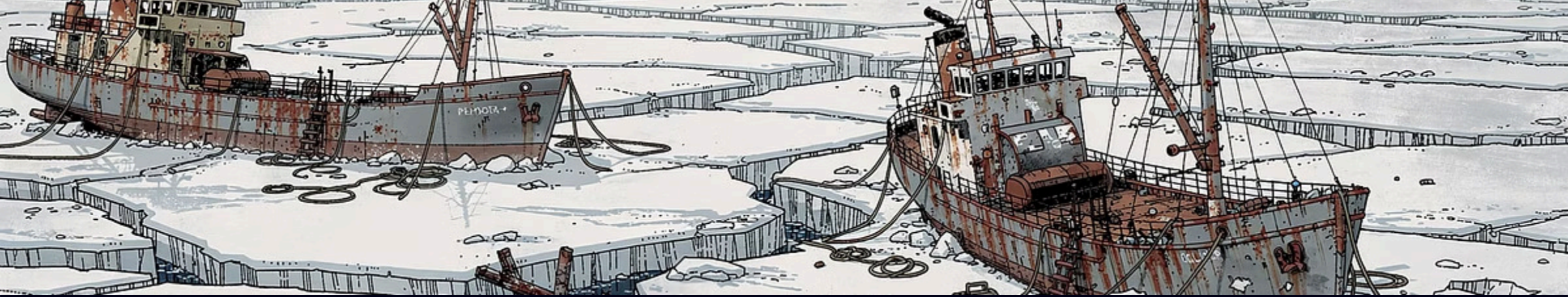
Sir John Franklin

Died 11 June 1847. Age 61. Commander of the expedition. His death removed the expedition's figurehead at a moment of severe crisis, and command devolved to Crozier under already desperate circumstances. For many of the officers and men, Franklin's death would have deepened the sense that the expedition was slipping beyond recovery.

Captain Francis Crozier

Assumed command following Franklin's death. Crozier was an experienced polar officer. It was Crozier who ultimately signed the Victory Point note in April 1848 and ordered the abandonment of the ships, the most consequential decision of the entire expedition.

By April 1848, the expedition had recorded a total of 24 deaths, nine officers and fifteen men. That figure is especially striking given that the ships had entered entrapment with full crews and a substantial supply base, suggesting how rapidly the situation had deteriorated over the intervening months. The rate of mortality during the period of entrapment significantly exceeded what might be expected from ordinary naval service or even from routine polar hardship. This elevated mortality reflects the compounding effects of prolonged ice imprisonment: depleted provisions, potential lead and scurvy-related illness, extreme cold, and the psychological deterioration attendant upon years of inactivity and diminishing hope. For Crozier and the 105 men who remained alive in April 1848, the situation had become existential.



Phase 4: Abandonment of the Ships (April 1848)

On 22 April 1848, Captain Francis Crozier ordered the abandonment of HMS Erebus and HMS Terror. Twenty-four men were already dead. The ships had been locked in the ice of Victoria Strait for nineteen months, and there was no indication that the coming season would bring any release. Provisions had fallen to a critical level, the health of the surviving officers and men was in severe decline, and remaining aboard had ceased to offer any realistic prospect of survival. With 105 men still living, Crozier concluded that the only remaining course of action was to leave the ships and attempt to reach inhabited territory overland. On that day, the men mustered on the ice, took up their sledge ropes, and departed.



Departure from the Ships

Before leaving, Crozier and Captain James Fitzjames deposited a written record at a cairn on King William Island, the document now known as the Victory Point note. Written in the margins of a standard Admiralty form, it recorded the position of the ships, the length of their entrapment, the number of deaths to date, and the decision to abandon the vessels and march for the Back River. It was signed by both officers and dated 25 April 1848. The note is the sole surviving written record from the expedition and remains one of the most significant documents in the history of Arctic exploration. The ships themselves were left behind along with the bulk of their remaining stores: two of the most technologically advanced vessels in the Royal Navy, fitted with steam engines and ice-reinforced hulls, abandoned on the frozen sea.



The Burden of the March

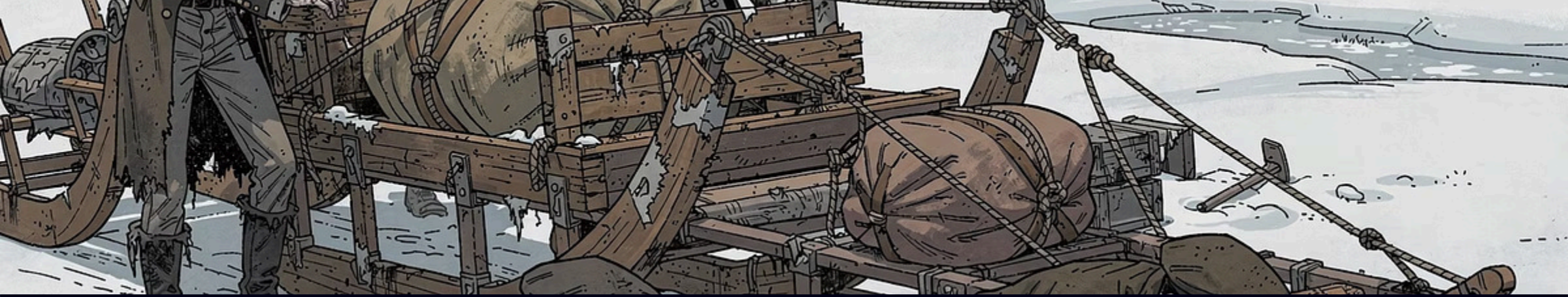
The men departed hauling heavy wooden boats mounted on sledges, a decision that has attracted sustained historical criticism. The boats were almost certainly retained in anticipation of river and coastal navigation further south, where open water would eventually have to be crossed. Nevertheless, the weight they imposed was enormous, and the sledges were loaded with a quantity of material that later searchers found difficult to account for. Francis McClintock's 1859 expedition recovered abandoned sledges whose loads included silverware, books, curtain rods, and other items of negligible survival value. The decision to carry such items, whether by individual choice or by oversight in the confusion of departure, added significantly to the burden the men would be required to haul from the very first day of the march.



Strategic Intent and Route

Crozier's plan was to march south across King William Island, reach the mouth of the Back River on the Canadian mainland, and ascend it into the interior, where there was at least a possibility of encountering indigenous peoples or a relief party. The route had a precedent: George Back had descended the same river in 1834 and demonstrated that it offered a navigable, if arduous, corridor toward inhabited territory. The total distance involved was formidable, hundreds of miles of Arctic terrain, including sea ice, tundra, and river systems, but given the options available, the Back River represented the most rational objective. It was a known route to the south, and for Crozier, it was the only viable one.

As the column formed up on the ice and the men leaned into their sledge harnesses, they carried with them the accumulated physical cost of nearly three years in the Arctic: nutritional deficiency, the effects of prolonged cold and inactivity, and whatever illness had already claimed twenty-four of their number. The scale of what lay ahead was not unknown to them. Hundreds of miles of some of the most hostile terrain in North America separated the men from any prospect of relief, and they would have to cover that distance on foot, in deteriorating condition, hauling loads that would have taxed fit men in summer. The ships that had been their home and shelter since 1845 now stood empty behind them on the ice. The march south had begun.



Phase 5: Final March and Total Loss

The column that moved south across King William Island in the spring and summer of 1848 was already a diminished and failing force. The men hauled their sledges and boats across fractured sea ice and over tundra that offered no shelter and no sustenance, their progress measurable in miles per day rather than miles per hour. Temperatures remained below freezing well into the season. The terrain was punishing: pressure ridges, open leads, and the uneven surface of coastal tundra demanded continuous physical effort from men who had little left to give. The evidence that allows historians to reconstruct this phase is fragmentary but consistent: skeletal remains found along the southern coast of King William Island and on the adjacent mainland, caches of abandoned equipment, the locations of makeshift campsites, and the accounts of Inuit witnesses who encountered the survivors or discovered their traces in the months and years that followed.



Physical Exhaustion and Exposure

The boats mounted on sledges weighed hundreds of pounds each, and the total loads were later estimated by McClintock's 1859 search party at figures that strained credibility even for healthy men. For men already weakened by nearly three years of inadequate nutrition, prolonged cold, and whatever illness had killed twenty-four of their number, the demands of the march were catastrophic. The distribution of human remains along the route, clustered at intervals consistent with men falling out of the column, suggests that attrition was rapid from the outset. Archaeological work at sites along the western and southern coasts of King William Island has recovered skeletal material showing evidence of advanced physiological stress.



Starvation and Disease

Scurvy would have been widespread by the time the march began, its effects — weakened connective tissue, profound fatigue, and psychological deterioration — compounding the physical demands at every level. Forensic analysis of skeletal remains has identified bone changes consistent with advanced scurvy in multiple individuals, including those who survived longest. Lead poisoning, likely from soldered tinned provisions, has been documented through bone and hair samples, with concentrations high enough to produce cognitive impairment and systemic toxicity. Caloric starvation in the final weeks would have precipitated multi-organ failure in men whose physiological reserves were already exhausted.



Forensic Evidence of Cannibalism

Forensic examination of skeletal remains from the NgLj-2 site at Erebus Bay, conducted by anthropologist Anne Keenleyside and colleagues in the 1990s, identified cut marks on human bones consistent with defleshing using a blade. Marrow extraction, indicated by fracture patterns of long bones, was also documented at the same sites. These findings were corroborated by Inuit accounts collected by John Rae in 1854, who reported that bodies of some of the dead had been mutilated and that flesh had been consumed. The convergence of forensic and testimonial evidence has been treated as conclusive by subsequent researchers, establishing beyond reasonable doubt that cannibalism occurred before the last survivors died.

The most substantial body of testimony concerning the expedition's final months was collected by the Hudson's Bay Company explorer John Rae in 1854, during a survey of the Boothia Peninsula. Rae encountered Inuit who reported encounters with groups of emaciated men travelling southward along the western coast of King William Island, apparently in the spring of 1848 or the years immediately following; subsequent accounts described the later discovery of bodies, abandoned boats, and scattered equipment. The accounts were geographically specific, internally consistent, and corroborated by physical relics: silver plate engraved with officers' initials, navigational instruments, and personal effects, which Rae purchased and brought back to Britain. The consistency of these oral accounts with the archaeological discoveries made by McClintock in 1859 and by researchers in the decades since has established Inuit testimony as an irreplaceable primary source for the expedition's end. Of the 129 men who sailed from England in May 1845, not one survived. The precise fate of the majority, where they fell, in what order, and under what circumstances, remains, in large part, unknown.



IV. Evidence Base and Methodology

The reconstruction of the Franklin narrative represents a methodological achievement in historical scholarship, demonstrating the power of synthesising documentary, physical, and oral historical evidence across more than 170 years of investigation. No single source is sufficient; it is the convergence of multiple independent lines of evidence that has produced the scholarly consensus now available.

1 The Victory Point Note

This is the primary written record of the expedition. A standard Royal Navy form deposited in a cairn in May 1847 and annotated with a margin update in April 1848, it provides the only direct documentary account of the besetment date (12 September 1846), Franklin's death (11 June 1847), the tally of 24 deaths, and Crozier's decision to abandon the ships. Its laconic naval prose renders it simultaneously invaluable and frustratingly incomplete.

3 Forensic Archaeology

Examination of the graves at Beechey Island and skeletal remains along the march route has provided direct physical data on crew health, causes of death, nutritional status, and, most controversially, evidence of cannibalism. The 1984 forensic examination of the Beechey Island graves by Owen Beattie represented a landmark in the application of modern scientific methods to historical cases.

2 Inuit Oral History

Local Inuit testimony has been instrumental in understanding the expedition's end. Accounts collected by Rae, Charles Francis Hall, and Frederick Schwatka in the mid-to-late 19th century described starving men, abandoned ships, and the locations of remains. Modern archaeologists credit Inuit oral knowledge, preserved across generations, as the decisive intelligence that directed the 2016 discovery of HMS Terror.

4 Search Expeditions and Artefact Recovery

The mid-19th-century search efforts launched by the Admiralty and by Lady Jane Franklin, though failing to locate survivors, systematically mapped much of the Canadian Arctic archipelago and recovered scattered artefacts, boat depots, and skeletal remains that have remained central to the evidentiary record.



V. The Franklin Expedition on Screen: AMC's *The Terror* (2018)

The expedition's legacy extends beyond history into modern storytelling and visual culture.

The Franklin Expedition's combination of imperial hubris, psychological disintegration, and total disappearance made it irresistible material for dramatic adaptation. AMC's *The Terror* (2018), produced by Ridley Scott and based on Dan Simmons' 2007 novel of the same name, is the most significant cinematic response to the expedition's legacy. The series follows the crews of HMS Erebus and HMS Terror through their entrapment and collapse, blending historical fidelity with supernatural horror.

The Tuunbaq

The series introduces the Tuunbaq, a monstrous creature drawn from Inuit mythology, as a supernatural predator stalking the stranded crew across the ice. In the show, Captain Sir John Franklin is violently killed by the Tuunbaq in episode three. The creature is deliberately kept obscured and partially unseen, consistent with the show's psychological horror approach.

Cinematography

Cinematographer Florian Hoffmeister BSC crafted a distinctive visual language for the series, described as richly detailed and hallucinatory. The show was shot almost entirely on closed soundstages at Stern Film Studio near Budapest, with the Arctic ice fields recreated using CGI technology also used in Ridley Scott's *The Martian*.

Production Design

Production designer Jonathan McKinstry built a single multipurpose ship set that could be modified to represent either HMS Terror or HMS Erebus. The ships were built on tilting rigs to simulate ice pressure, and Hoffmeister spent three weeks in pre-production testing the visual look, treating the series as a feature rather than episodic TV.

Historical Fidelity

The production consulted Canadian archaeologist Matthew Betts, who had worked on detailed models of HMS Terror, and sourced blueprints from London's National Maritime Museum. The discovery of the actual wrecks in 2014 and 2016 allowed the production team to incorporate newly available archaeological detail into the set design.

Executive producers David Kajganich and Soo Hugh described their mandate as to infuse death with a subjective point of view, from a psychologically almost surreal vantage point. The Tuunbaq functions not merely as a monster but as a manifestation of the Arctic itself, unknowable, indifferent, and lethal.

VI. Modern Discoveries and Conclusion

The discovery of the wrecks by Parks Canada transformed the Franklin expedition from a historical mystery into an active subject of underwater archaeology. The location of HMS Erebus in 2014, in relatively shallow water approximately 80 kilometres south of King William Island, was followed two years later by the even more remarkable discovery of HMS Terror in Terror Bay, a finding that fundamentally altered scholarly understanding of the expedition's final months.



HMS Erebus (2014)

Located in shallow Arctic waters approximately 80 km south of King William Island. The discovery confirmed aspects of Inuit testimony regarding the ship's final resting place and inaugurated a sustained programme of Parks Canada underwater archaeological investigation.



HMS Terror (2016)

Found in Terror Bay in a state of extraordinary preservation, sitting upright on the seabed with hatches closed and window glass intact. Interior spaces including crew quarters, a mess hall, and food storage remain visible, constituting an archaeological time capsule of unparalleled significance.

The condition of HMS Terror in particular demands scholarly attention. A vessel crushed or sunk violently by ice would not present the ordered, intact appearance documented by the Parks Canada diving team. The closed hatches and undamaged glazing suggest that Terror settled in sheltered, relatively calm water, raising the possibility that the ship was intentionally repositioned after the April 1848 abandonment, perhaps by a remnant crew seeking a survivable refuge. This hypothesis remains unconfirmed but is actively being investigated through ongoing underwater archaeological work.

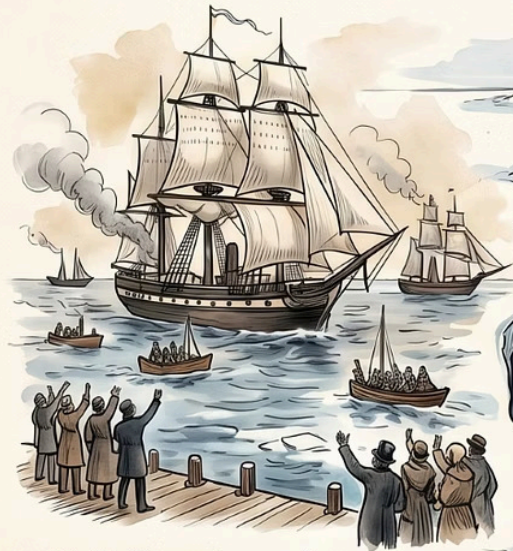
The Franklin expedition endures as a subject of scholarly fascination because of the stark contrast between its high-technology, supremely confident departure and its silent, total disappearance. While the Victory Point note provides a skeleton chronology, the ongoing archaeological programme on the Erebus and Terror continues to generate new evidence, ensuring that the scholarly understanding of the expedition's final chapters remains dynamic, contested, and profoundly significant to the history of polar exploration.

- ① Archaeological investigation of both wrecks is ongoing under the joint stewardship of Parks Canada and Inuit partners. The integration of Inuit Qaujimajatuqangit, traditional knowledge, into the archaeological programme represents a model of collaborative historical inquiry with implications well beyond the Franklin case.

The Silence of the Ice: The Franklin Expedition

In 1845, the Royal Navy dispatched *HMS Erebus* and *HMS Terror* to find the Northwest Passage. The mission, equipped with state-of-the-art technology, vanished until a single note and modern archaeology revealed a harrowing story of entrapment and collapse.

1845–1848: The Descent into Ice



1845: Departure of the High-Tech Fleet

129 men sailed on steam-assisted, ice-strengthened ships with three years of provisions.

1846–1847: The Fatal Entrapment

Ships remained ice-locked for 19 months; Commander Sir John Franklin died in June 1847.

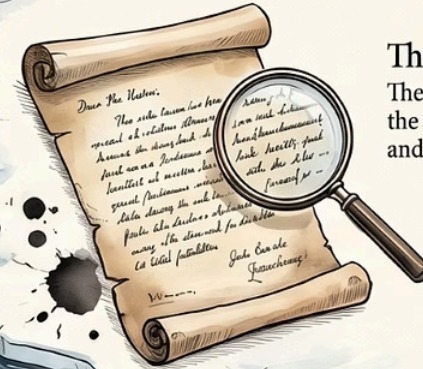


1848: Abandonment and Final March

105 survivors deserted the ships to attempt a desperate, lethal trek toward the mainland.



1848–Present: Evidence and Discovery



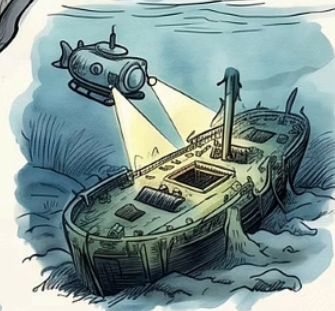
The Victory Point Note

The sole written record confirming the abandonment, Franklin's death, and 24 total fatalities.



Inuit Oral Testimony

Local knowledge preserved the truth of the disaster long before European searchers found evidence.



2014 & 2016: Modern Rediscovery

Erebus and *Terror* were located underwater, the latter found remarkably intact in Terror Bay.